OTHER SPECIAL FORCES

Since World War II armies have recognized the usefulness of elite troops, capable of operating in small units deep behind enemy lines in conventional warfare or as counter-insurgency forces against guerrillas. All special forces operate rigorous selection procedures and gruelling training programmes, with an emphasis upon individual initiative, mental strength, controlled aggression, and survival under difficult conditions. In reaction to the mass combat of the World Wars, special forces represent a reassertion of professionalism and of quality over quantity of troops. Since the 1970s, counter-terrorist warfare has been a central concern of special forces, and techniques for dealing with hostage-taking situations have been shared between states.

ISRAELI SPECIAL FORCES

In the guerrilla warfare that led to the creation of the state of Israel in 1948, the Israelis developed a tradition of ruthless covert operations involving raids inside hostile territory, sabotage, and assassination. This was carried forward into their conflict with Arab states and with paramilitary organizations around Israel's borders after independence. Israel's first special forces group, Unit 101, led by Ariel Sharon, was disbanded in 1953 after a notorious raid into the West Bank in which 69 Palestinian civilians were massacred. It was succeeded by other special forces units, however, including Sayeret Golani, Sayeret T'zanhanim, and the most famous, Sayeret Matkal (popularly known as "The Unit").

Founded in 1958, Sayeret Matkal was originally a top-secret unit recruited through personal and family contacts, somewhat like Britain's wartime SOE. This partially explains its close links with Israel's governing elite. Sayeret Matkal is now staffed by volunteers who have survived a ferociously demanding selection course. It has established a formidable reputation for intelligence-gathering and sabotage raids deep into Arab territory. Many of its operations have remained shrouded in secrecy; they are believed often to involve the assassination of suspected enemies of Israel. Sayeret Matkal also specializes in dealing with hostage-taking situations. Its most highly publicized success was the freeing of hostages held by terrorists at Entebbe airport in Uganda in July, 1976.



Galil assault rifle
Designed by Israel Galil in 1974, this light, gas-operated assault rifle is the Israeli answer to the Russian AK47. It is based on the Finnish Valmet M62 and chambered for the Amercian 5.56 x 45 round.

GSG-9

Germany's lack of an adequate counter-terrorist force was revealed by a bungled response to hostage-taking by Palestinian terrorists at the 1972 Munich Olympics. GSG-9 (Grenzschutz-gruppe-9, or "Border Guards, Group 9") went operational on 17 April 1973. Its name suggested that it was part of Federal Germany's border guards, although in practice it was a totally new organization within the country's police force. Under the strong leadership of Ulrich Wegener, GSG-9 quickly developed into an elite counter-terrorist organization. In the 1970s, Federal Germany faced a home-grown terrorist movement, known as the Red Army Faction. In October 1977 a group of terrorists led by Zohair Akache, a Palestinian, hijacked a Lufthansa airliner with 86 passengers on board. They demanded the release of Red Army Faction prisoners in Germany in return for the passengers' safe release. After the captain of the aircraft had been murdered by the terrorists, GSG-9 operatives supported by two SAS men stormed the hijacked airliner at Mogadishu airport, Somalia. Three of the four terrorists were killed in an exchange of fire, while only one hostage was injured. The Mogadishu operation made GSG-9's reputation – one which has been confirmed by subsequent operations.



Troop carrier
Bell Huey troop carriers are among the helicopters used by GSG-9 to fly officers anywhere in Germany.



GSG-9 INSIGNIA